Writing a Complete Answer

Plan, write and check in 20 minutes.

The 20-minute budget

2 min	Plan: read the question, note the overview, the grouping and 3–4 key figures per body paragraph.
15 min	Write all four parts. Keep going forward; fix small errors later.
3 min	Check tense, the overview and your word count.

Read the question first

- **Graph type** and how many lines
- **Time period:** start, end and the total span
- **Units:** %, thousands, litres per day. Check the brackets.
- **Every category:** you can group them, but you can't leave one out

How long?

Introduction	25–30 words
Overview	30–40 words
Body paragraph 1	50–60 words
Body paragraph 2	50–60 words

Write at least 150 words. A short answer may not cover the key features.

Self-editing: six questions

1. Have I selected the main features, with figures that match the graph?
2. Does my overview summarise the pattern rather than recount detail?
3. Are my comparisons between equivalent figures?
4. Is my grouping logical?
5. Are my words precise, and does the tense match the time?
6. Do the links between sentences make sense: *in contrast* for a contrast, *meanwhile* for the same time?

The four marking criteria

Task Achievement	every category, a clear overview, accurate figures, 150+ words
Coherence and Cohesion	clear paragraphs, links that fit the ideas
Lexical Resource	precise words, a range where it helps
Grammatical Range and Accuracy	correct tense, comparatives, complex sentences

Last-minute check

- **Did I compare?** At least one comparison in the overview and in each body paragraph
- Past simple for recorded years
- 10 **million**, not millions
- Every figure has its unit
- No opinions, no reasons